▼ GLASSHOUSE



TROUBLE FOR THE TROIKA

Disgruntlement is simmering in the Congress after the Bihar poll debacle, with many leaders privately directing fire at AICC general secretary (organisation) K.C. Venugopal, treasurer Ajay Maken and Bihar in-charge Krishna Allavaru, three key Rahul Gandhi confidants who "have not won a direct election in over a decade". Venugopal has been accused of gatekeeping access to Rahul; Maken has presided over lacklustre outcomes in Chhattisgarh (2023), Haryana (2024) and now Bihar; and former corporate honcho Allavaru, a key strategist behind Rahul's Vote Adhikar Yatra, faces criticism for the initial stalemate in seat-sharing talks with the RJD, delaying preparations for both allies. The perception that a small, unelected coterie continues to dominate strategy despite repeated electoral setbacks has sharpened demands for accountability. Will the Bihar outcome change that?

Illustrations by **SIDDHANT JUMDE**

▼ UNSETTLING BANTER

SWEET NOTHING?

Uttar Pradesh deputy CM **Keshav Prasad Maurya** has added a sugary twist to his political banter with Samajwadi Party chief **Akhilesh Yadav**. Speaking to reporters, Maurya told them how, during a brief exchange at Patna airport in the midst of the Bihar poll, the SP chief asked him, "*Laddu kab khila rahe ho?*" Maurya said he looked for Akhilesh on November 14, the day the poll results were declared, "but couldn't find him". He has now sent a public invite offering not just laddu but rasgulla too. A clip of the airport moment, when the two leaders shared a laugh, went viral, with Akhilesh quipping that it had unsettled CM Yogi Adityanath and sharpened the BJP's communal pitch. Maurya's jibe, then, is another aside in this bout of political one-upmanship.

